

The Core Divide: Capitalism vs. Communism

- Two opposing blueprints for society emerged post-WWII.
- United States championed Democratic Capitalism.
- Soviet Union enforced Authoritarian Communism.
- Ideological clash replaced a fragile wartime alliance.



The post-WWII world fractured into two distinct ideological blueprints: individual enterprise versus state-directed collective action.

Defining the Systems: Individual vs. State

- Capitalism: Free markets and individual property rights.
- Communism: State control and collective ownership.
- Democracy emphasizes personal liberty and voting.
- Authoritarianism mandates strict obedience to the state.



Capitalism relies on private ownership, competition, and individual choice.



Communism relies on total state control to enforce collective equality and resource distribution.

Mental Model: The Group Project Analogy

- System A (Capitalism): Choose roles, earn individual grades.
- System B (Communism): Assigned roles, earn shared grades.
- Non-example: Neither system is a chaotic free-for-all.
- Both aim for societal success using opposite motivations.



System A: Individual effort leads to distinct, individualized rewards.



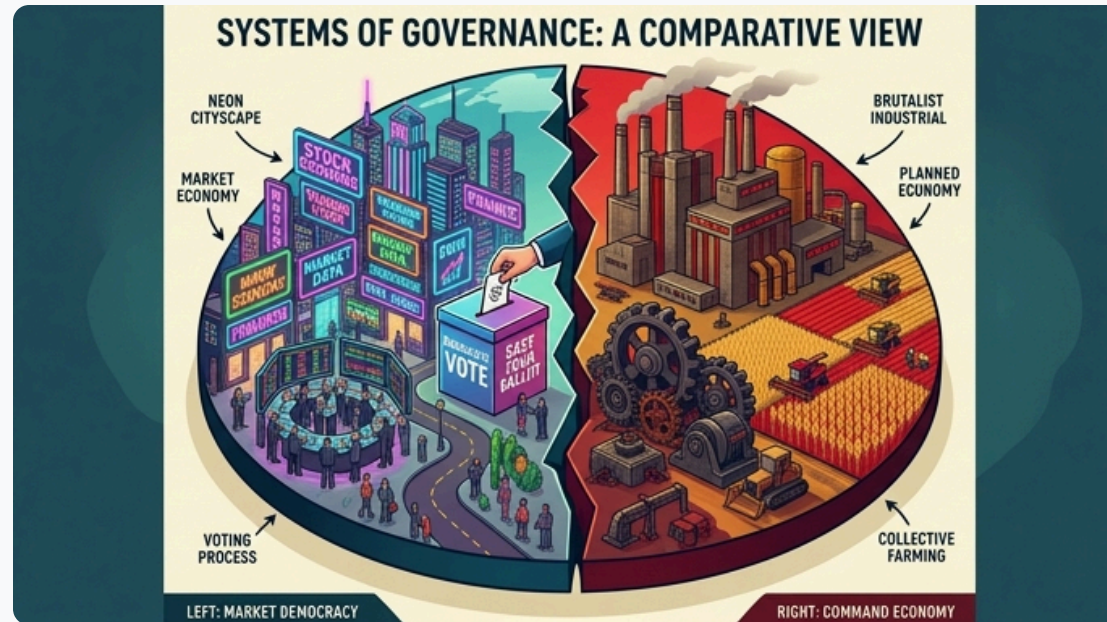
System B: Assigned roles result in an equal, collective reward regardless of individual effort.

The Inevitable Clash Post-WWII

- WWII alliance was purely strategic against a common enemy.
- Post-war rebuilding goals were inherently incompatible.
- US sought open global markets for economic growth.
- USSR sought secure buffer zones and ideological conformity.

The Post-WWII Ideological Divide

- WWII alliance between US and USSR ends
- Two rival global superpowers emerge
- Fundamentally incompatible societal models



The post-WWII world was immediately split into two fundamentally opposing ideological spheres.

Contrasting Systems: US vs. USSR

- US: Free markets and private ownership
- US: Multi-party elections and individual rights
- USSR: State-owned economy and agriculture
- USSR: Single-party rule for collective equality



Democratic Capitalism: Emphasizing private ownership, free markets, and individual rights.



Authoritarian Communism: Emphasizing state control, collective labor, and strict political uniformity.

Why Cooperation Failed

- Capitalism does NOT guarantee equal wealth
- Communism does NOT value individual consumer choice
- Core values were exact opposites
- Post-war diplomatic partnership became impossible

Not Just a War for Territory

- Traditional wars fight for land or resources
- The Cold War was a clash of absolute worldviews
- A fundamental struggle between two incompatible systems



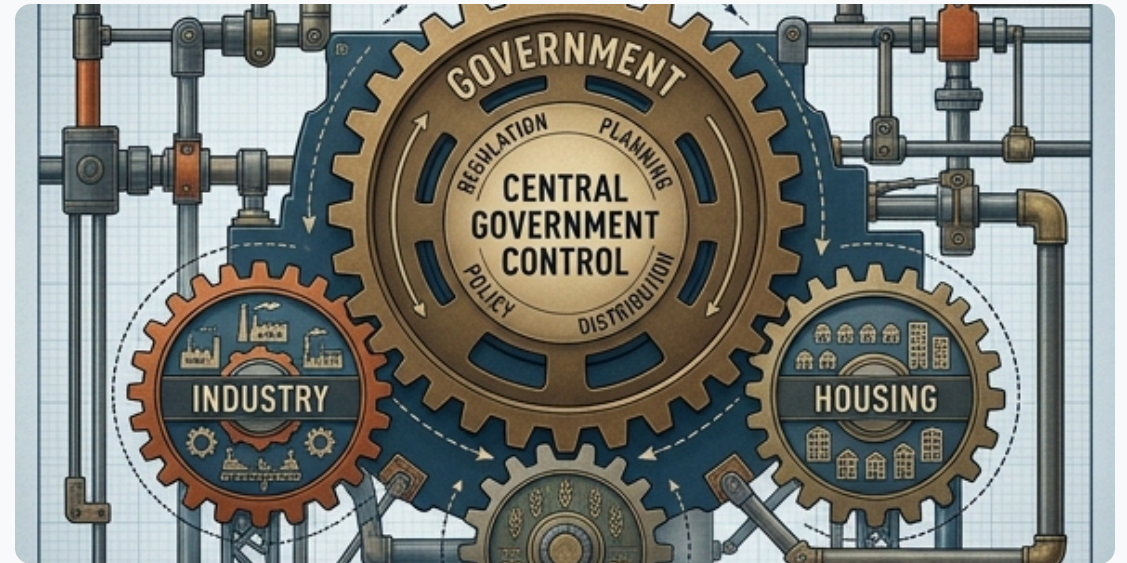
The Cold War was an ideological struggle for the future of global society, not just a fight over physical borders.

Clearing Misconceptions: What Communism is NOT

- Basic public services $\neq$ Communism
- Roads, schools, and fire departments exist in capitalism
- Public goods are funded by taxes, not total state control



Public services like schools are standard functions of government, not 'communism'.



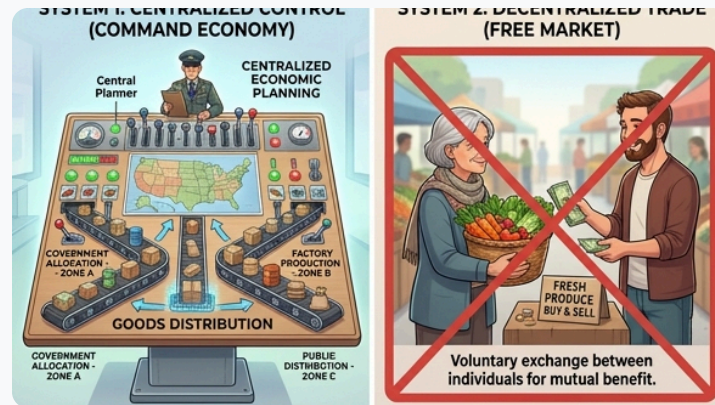
Soviet communism requires state ownership of all production, not just basic public goods.

The Core Traits of Soviet Communism

- Elimination of private property
- Abolition of free market economics
- Eradication of opposing political parties



Private ownership was abolished and replaced by collective state ownership.



Prices and production were dictated by the government, not supply and demand.



Political opposition was banned, ensuring a single-party authoritarian rule.

An Absolute Divide

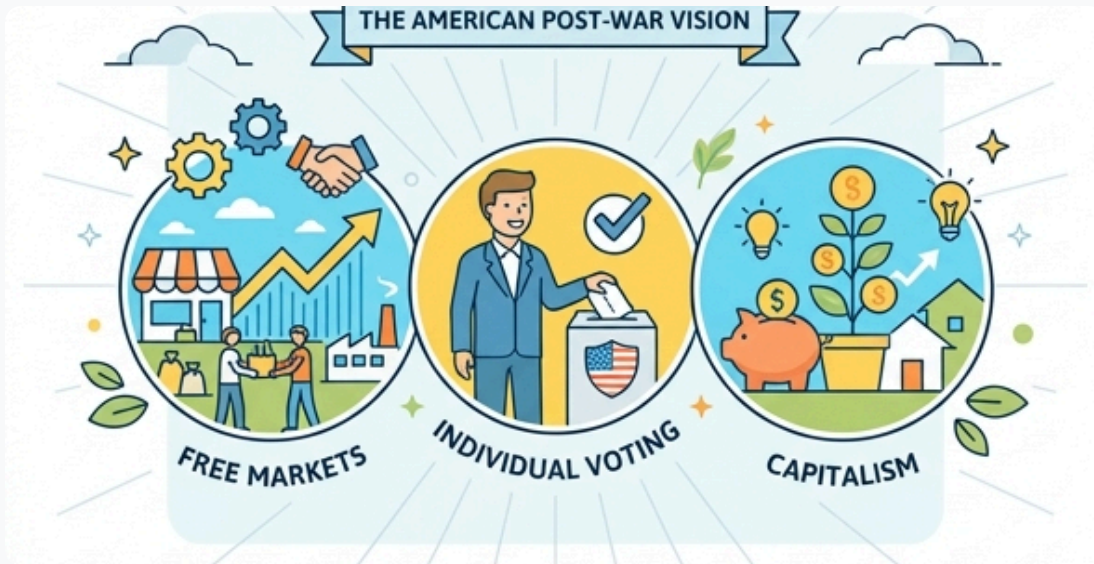
- Worldviews were structurally incompatible
- Ideology drove global geopolitical strategy
- A zero-sum game: one side's gain is the other's loss

The WWII Alliance: A Temporary Truce

- Allied from 1941 to 1945 against Nazi Germany
- United strictly by a shared enemy, not shared values
- Functioned as a strategic 'marriage of convenience'

The Sudden Pivot (1945)

- Defeat of Germany removed the shared threat
- Alliance instantly collapsed without a common enemy
- Clashing visions for post-war reconstruction emerged



The US vision prioritized free markets and individual rights for rebuilding Europe.



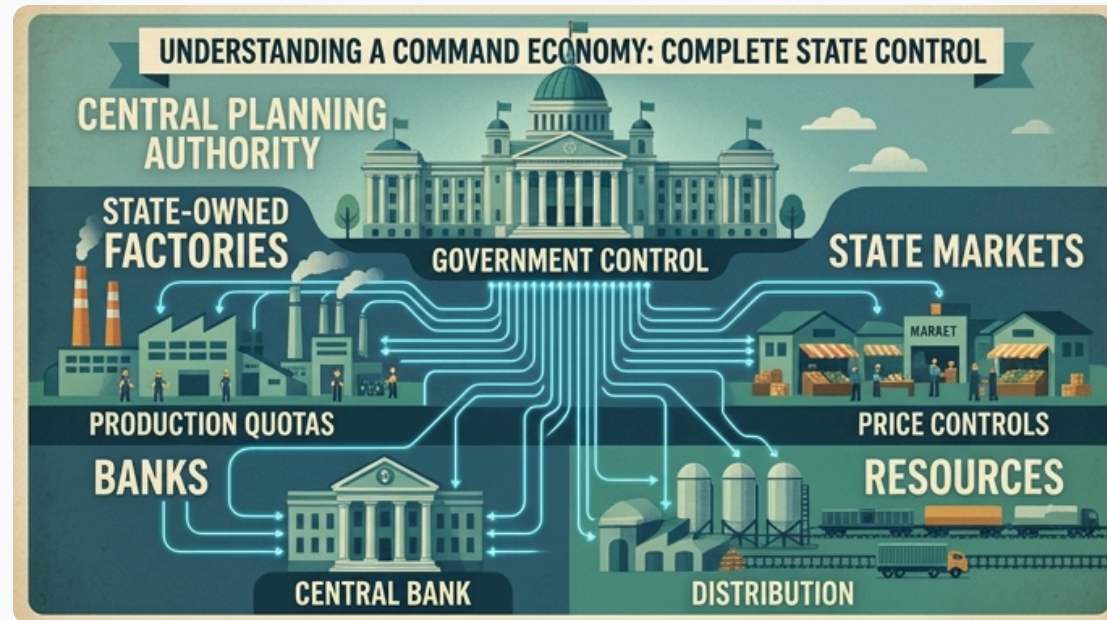
The Soviet vision prioritized state control and collective equality.

Why Cooperation Failed

- Non-example: The WWII alliance was never a true friendship
- Fundamentally incompatible visions for society and economy
- Democratic capitalism vs. authoritarian communism
- Ideological differences made the Cold War inevitable

Knowledge Check: Identifying the Ideology

- A post-WWII nation seeks to prevent poverty.
- Government takes ownership of all private banks.
- The state dictates the prices of all goods.
- Citizens are directly assigned jobs by the government.



Visualizing a state-controlled economy where the central government manages all resources and infrastructure.

Which Ideology Is It?

- Option A: Democratic Capitalism (United States)
- Option B: Authoritarian Communism (Soviet Union)
- Consider who controls the means of production and distribution.



Capitalism emphasizes free markets, supply and demand, and private ownership.



Communism relies on strict state control and the collective distribution of goods.

The Answer: Authoritarian Communism

- Correct Answer: The Soviet Union.
- Defining Trait: Absolute state control over the economy.
- Non-Example: Free-market capitalism (prices fluctuate based on supply and demand).
- Conclusion: This fundamental incompatibility made post-WWII cooperation impossible.